

Free PDF Guide

5 Brain Games to Calm Your Dog in 5 Minutes

Simple mental exercises based on professional dog training methods — adapted for busy pet owners who want a calmer, better-behaved dog without force or

frustration.

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5-Minute Exercises

No Equipment Needed

All Breeds & Ages

What's Inside

Game 1: The Muffin Tin Game — The foundational brain game that started it all

Game 2: The Shell Game — Build focus and impulse control with this classic challenge

Game 3: The "Find It" Trail — Channel scent-tracking instincts into calm behavior

Game 4: The Cup-Stacking Challenge — Teach sequence, memory, and body control

Game 5: The "New Trick" Session — The ultimate brain workout for ongoing training

Each game takes just 5 minutes or less. No special equipment required. Start with Game 1 and progress at your own pace.

Game 1 of 5

The Muffin Tin Game

5 minutes • All breeds • Beginner

This is the foundational brain game. It teaches your dog to use their nose and problem-solving skills simultaneously — which means their brain is working hard while their body stays calm. Most owners see a noticeable difference the very first time.

WHAT YOU NEED

1 standard 6-cup muffin tin	6 dog treats (small, smelly ones work best)	6 tennis balls or similar-sized balls
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HOW TO PLAY

1. Place one treat in each cup of the muffin tin. Let your dog watch you do this so they understand what they're working for.
2. Place one tennis ball on top of each cup, covering the treats. Your dog can see the cups but can't access the treats directly.
3. Present the muffin tin to your dog and give a cue like "Find them!" or "Go search!"
4. Let your dog figure out how to remove the balls to access the treats. Don't help them — the mental work IS the point.
5. Once they've retrieved all treats, praise calmly and put the tin away. This signals that the "work session" is over.

WHY THIS WORKS

This game engages your dog's olfactory system (smelling the treats under the balls) while requiring problem-solving (figuring out how to move the balls). This combination activates multiple brain regions at once, providing the mental stimulation that calms hyperactive and anxious dogs.

PRO TIP

If your dog gets frustrated after 2 minutes, lift one ball to show them "there's something under here" — but then reset and let them work it out. The goal is effort, not perfection.

PROGRESS TRACKER

Day	Goal	Notes
1-2	Dog finds treats with some guidance	Be patient — they're learning the concept
3-5	Dog removes balls independently	Start using the verbal cue consistently
7+	Dog solves in under 60 seconds	Time them! Speed means their brain is engaged

Game 2 of 5

The Shell Game

5 minutes • All breeds • Beginner

You've seen this at a street performer's stand — now it's your dog's turn. This game builds focus, impulse control, and working memory. Dogs who "can't pay attention" suddenly can't look away.

WHAT YOU NEED

3 identical opaque cups or containers

1 high-value treat (something your dog goes crazy for)

A quiet room with minimal distractions

HOW TO PLAY

1. Show your dog the treat, then place it under one of three cups while they watch.
2. Say "Find it!" and let your dog indicate which cup has the treat (nosing, pawing, or looking).
3. If they're correct, lift the cup and give them the treat with calm praise.
4. If they're wrong, show them where the treat actually is, but don't give it to them. Reset and try again.
5. Repeat 5-10 times. As they get better, shuffle the cups slowly before letting them choose.

WHY THIS WORKS

This game requires sustained attention and impulse control — two things hyperactive dogs struggle with. By making it fun and rewarding, you're training their brain to focus on a task instead of seeking stimulation through barking, jumping, or chewing.

PRO TIP

Start easy — don't shuffle at first. Just let them pick the right cup. Only add difficulty (shuffling, longer waits) once they're succeeding 80% of the time at the current level.

DIFFICULTY LEVELS

Level	Difficulty	When to Advance
Level 1	No shuffling, treat visible at start	8/10 correct
Level 2	Slow shuffle after treat is hidden	7/10 correct
Level 3	Shuffle + 5-second wait before "Find it!"	7/10 correct
Level 4	Shuffle + 15-second wait + distractions	Consistent success

Game 3 of 5

The "Find It" Trail

5-7 minutes • All breeds • Intermediate

This game channels your dog's natural scent-tracking instincts into a controlled, mentally exhausting activity. It's especially powerful for dogs who pull on leash or bark at everything — because their nose is busy, their brain is engaged, and their energy is being spent productively.

WHAT YOU NEED

10-15 small treats (smelly ones like freeze-dried liver)

A room with furniture to hide treats behind/under

A leash (optional, for controlling the search area)

HOW TO PLAY

1. Put your dog in a "stay" or hold their leash. Show them 3-4 treats.
2. Place the treats around the room at nose height — on chair legs, behind a pillow, next to a table leg. Make them visible at first.
3. Release your dog with the cue "Find it!" and let them collect all the treats.
4. Once they succeed 3 times, start hiding treats in harder spots — under a newspaper, behind a closed door crack, inside a cardboard box.
5. Increase difficulty gradually: more treats, harder hiding spots, longer search time before release.

WHY THIS WORKS

Scent work is one of the most mentally exhausting activities for a dog. A 5-minute "Find It" session is equivalent to a 30-minute walk in terms of mental stimulation. Dogs who are tired mentally are calm physically — which means less barking, less chewing, and better behavior overall.

PRO TIP

Hide treats in the evening before you play. By game time, the scent has dispersed slightly, making it a bit harder — and harder = more brain work = calmer dog.

DIFFICULTY LEVELS

Round	Hiding Difficulty	Example
Round 1	Visible at nose height	On chair leg, behind cup
Round 2	Partially hidden	Under newspaper, in open box
Round 3	Fully hidden, easy spots	Behind door, under cushion
Round 4	Fully hidden, harder spots	Inside folded towel, under shoe

Game 4 of 5

The Cup-Stacking Challenge

5 minutes • Medium+ breeds • Intermediate

This game teaches your dog to follow a sequence of actions — building a chain of behaviors that requires memory, patience, and body awareness. It's the bridge between simple brain games and actual training commands.

WHAT YOU NEED

3-5 plastic cups of different sizes

1 treat

A non-slip surface (carpet or yoga mat)

HOW TO PLAY

1. Place a treat under one cup while your dog watches. Say "Find it!" and let them knock over the cup to get the treat. Repeat 3 times.
2. Now stack 2 cups (treat under the bottom one). Say "Find it!" Let them figure out they need to knock the top cup first, then the bottom one.
3. Gradually increase to 3, then 4, then 5 cups in a stack. The treat is always under the LAST cup.
4. Your dog must knock down the entire stack in sequence to reach the reward. This requires planning and body control.
5. Once mastered, try arranging cups in a line instead of a stack — treat under the last one in the row.

WHY THIS WORKS

This game requires your dog to understand sequence and cause-and-effect at a higher level. They can't just nose one cup — they have to work through a problem systematically. This level of cognitive engagement is what produces the "calm after the game" effect that owners report.

PRO TIP

If your dog gets frustrated knocking down the stack, go back to 2 cups and rebuild. The goal is success at each level before adding complexity. Frustration shuts down learning.

DIFFICULTY LEVELS

Level	Setup	Mastery
Level 1	1 cup, treat underneath	Instant retrieval
Level 2	2-cup stack	Knocks in sequence
Level 3	3-cup stack	Confident, no hesitation
Level 4	4-5 cup stack or line	Completes in under 30 seconds

Game 5 of 5

The "New Trick" Session

5 minutes • All breeds • Advanced

Teaching a brand-new trick is the ultimate brain workout. Unlike practicing known commands, learning something new forces the brain to form new neural connections. This game shows you the exact method — and you can teach ANY trick using this approach.

WHAT YOU NEED

High-value treats (tiny pieces — you'll use many)

A clicker or verbal marker word ("Yes!")

A quiet environment and a 5-minute timer

HOW TO PLAY (Example: Teaching "Spin")

1. Hold a treat near your dog's nose. Slowly move it in a circle so they have to turn to follow it.
2. The moment they complete the circle, mark ("Yes!" or click) and give the treat.
3. Repeat 5-10 times until they're anticipating the circle and starting to turn on their own.
4. Now add the verbal cue "Spin!" right before you lure with the treat. Repeat 5 times.
5. Try saying "Spin!" without the treat lure in your hand. If they spin, mark and reward heavily. If not, go back to luring for a few more reps.

6. Practice 5 times per day for 3 days. By day 3, most dogs respond to the verbal cue alone.

WHY THIS WORKS

Learning a new behavior requires maximum cognitive effort. Your dog has to figure out what you're asking, coordinate their body, and associate a new word with an action. This is the mental equivalent of a full-body workout — and just like physical exercise, it produces a calm, satisfied dog afterward.

PRO TIP

Other tricks to teach using the same method: "Touch" (nose to your hand), "Over" (jump onto a couch), "Crawl" (belly under a chair), "Tuck" (go to bed). Pick one new trick per week for ongoing brain training.

WEEKLY TRICK SCHEDULE

Week	Trick Ideas	Difficulty
Week 1	Spin, Sit pretty	Easy
Week 2	Touch (nose to hand), Over	Easy-Medium
Week 3	Crawl, Roll over	Medium
Week 4	Play dead, Bow	Medium-Hard

Your Dog's Brain Is Already Changing

If you've completed all five games, you've already begun transforming your dog's behavior. The research is clear: dogs who receive daily mental stimulation show measurable reductions in stress-related behaviors within just 7-14 days.

What to Do Next

- **Keep going.** Play one game per day, rotating through all five. Variety keeps your dog engaged.
- **Track progress.** Note which games your dog enjoys most and which produce the calmest results.
- **Increase difficulty.** As your dog masters each level, add complexity to keep their brain challenged.
- **Want the full program?** The complete Brain Training for Dogs includes 21 brain games, 7 training modules, and step-by-step video demonstrations.

Remember: a tired brain creates a calm body. You're not just entertaining your dog — you're giving them the mental workout they've been missing.

Disclaimer: This guide is for educational purposes only. If your dog shows signs of aggression, severe anxiety, or other serious behavioral issues, consult a certified professional dog trainer or veterinary behaviorist. The author is not liable for any injuries or damages resulting from the use of these techniques.